

THAKBE?

Pellichupulu — but she wasn't ready, and he was forty minutes early.

Genre: Romantic Comedy **Format:** Short Series **Duration:** 60 Episodes × 2–2.5 Mins **Cast:** 2 Artists. Nobody else on screen, ever. **Location:** ONE flat. Hall, kitchen, bathroom door, bedroom door, balcony. **Story timeline:** Friday 4:10 PM → Monday 11:00 AM **Screen timeline:** Non-linear. See Section 4. **Tagline:** *Nuvvu emi antunnavo naaku telidu. Kani naaku telusu. / Tumi ki bolcho ami jani na. Kintu ami jani.*

1. LOGLINE

He arrives forty minutes early to meet the girl his father chose; she opens the door in a nightdress with a face pack on and dye in her hair, and by the time she has made herself presentable, a cyclone has closed the only airport that could have ended this.

2. PITCH

Vikram Aditya knows four things about the girl: a first name, a photograph, an address in Gachibowli, and that his father says it's a good family. He did not read the rest. He has never had to read the rest. He says yes to things.

He lands early, the cab is fast, and at 4:10 on a Friday afternoon he rings a doorbell forty minutes before he is supposed to.

The door opens on Shilpaa, in a nightdress, with a green face pack drying on her cheeks, hair dye clipped up under a shower cap, and thirty-eight minutes left on a timer she cannot stop without ruining both.

What she says, in careful, clipped English, is: *"You are early. Sit. I need forty minutes."*

What she says two seconds later, walking away, under her breath, in the language she actually thinks in — is a great deal more.

He doesn't know what it is. He will not know what it is for twelve episodes.

Because Shilpaa Bose talks to herself. Constantly. In Bengali. It is how she works out what she feels, it has been since she was six, and it does not occur to her to stop just because a

stranger is sitting in her hall — he can't understand it, so it isn't really out loud.

He can hear every syllable. He just can't decode a single one. So he starts writing them down.

Over three days — a cancelled flight, a closed airport, a rain that will not stop, and one entirely accidental cohabitation — a man who has never chosen anything in his life teaches himself ninety-one words of a language he did not know she spoke, in order to find out what a woman has been saying about him while standing four feet away.

And she finds out he's been listening.

By Monday at eleven, both families are at the door and both of these people have made up their minds. What neither of them has worked out — and what the last thirty seconds of the season puts on screen — is what this is actually going to be like.

3. THE THREE ENGINES

3.1 THE MUTTER

The single most important device in the series.

Shilpaa thinks out loud, in Bengali, all the time. She is not performing. She is not hiding behind it. It is simply the language her interior monologue happens in, and she has done it since she was a child.

- **The audience gets subtitles. Vikram does not.**
- She does it in front of him because at first he is a stranger who can't understand, and later because it is automatic and she has stopped noticing.
- Roughly **three mutters per episode**. Some are throwaway. Some are the truest thing in the episode.
- **The comedy:** he hears the sounds and builds a private, wrong theory about each one.
- **The romance:** he starts writing them down phonetically, in the back of a diary, and decoding them one at a time — which means the audience watches a man slowly gain access to a woman's inner life, one misspelt word at a time.
- **The running gag with teeth:** he repeats a mutter back to her, out loud, having decoded it wrongly. Four times across the season. Three are catastrophic. The fourth, in Episode 60, is correct.

Direction note: she never mutters *at* him. Her body is always turned away, occupied, mid-

task. If she plays it as a stage aside, the device dies.

3.2 THE FORTY MINUTES

Episodes 1 to 11 take place across one forty-minute window while she gets ready, and they are a different show from the other forty-nine episodes.

In this window:

- **She speaks only English.** Short, clipped, functional. She sounds like a colleague.
- **He speaks only Telugu**, with a few English words thrown at her when he sees she isn't following.
- **Her Bengali exists only as mutters** — through a closed bathroom door, from another room, under her breath.
- **Nothing about Kolkata, her father, or her mother is said.**

He spends this window assuming she is a slightly cold, very organised South Indian girl with a phone call going on in the bathroom.

He is wrong about every part of that.

The reveal lands at the end of Episode 12 — and the whole first act reads as a completely different series on a rewatch, which is exactly what the compilation cut is for.

3.3 THE WORD

Episode 9. Through the bathroom door, to herself, about a plant she has been failing to keep alive on the balcony, she says: "*Thakbe?*" — *will you stay?*

He hears it. He writes it down. "**THOK BEE — ?**"

He decodes it wrong in Episode 22 and it means "thank you" to him for the next twenty episodes.

He uses it wrongly in Episode 34, for comedy.

He finds out what it actually means in Episode 51 and says nothing.

He uses it correctly in Episode 59. It is the proposal. It is four syllables long and there is no music under it.

4. THE NON-LINEAR STRUCTURE

The series does not run in time order. It runs in **four loops**, each of which opens on a charged moment out of sequence, rewinds, and returns to close on that same frame from the other side.

4.1 The Master Loop

Episode 1 opens on Monday 11:00 AM — the doorbell, both families outside, Vikram and Shilpaa standing in the hall looking at each other. Twelve seconds. No context. No dialogue.

Then: **"68 HOURS EARLIER."**

And the series runs from Friday 4:10 PM.

Episode 59 arrives back at that exact frame — same lens, same blocking, same light — and plays past it.

4.2 The Act Loops

Each act opens on a flash-forward from inside that act and resolves it before the act ends.

Loop	Opens on (Ep)	Flash-forward is from	Resolves (Ep)
Master	Ep 1 — Monday 11 AM, the doorbell	Ep 59	Ep 59
Loop A	Ep 2 — her hand on the bathroom door, not opening it	Ep 12	Ep 12
Loop B	Ep 13 — him alone on the balcony at 2 AM saying a Bengali word wrong	Ep 22	Ep 22
Loop C	Ep 31 — the two of them shouting at each other in two languages, furious	Ep 38	Ep 38
Loop D	Ep 46 — her crying, alone, holding his diary	Ep 51	Ep 51

4.3 The Rule

Every flash-forward is a lie by omission, never by content. The audience sees a true frame with the context stripped out. Ep 31's fight looks like a break-up and is in fact the funniest scene in the series. Ep 46's crying looks like heartbreak and is not.

Never cheat the image. Never shoot a flash-forward that plays differently once you know — only one that *means* differently.

4.4 Title card grammar

Only four cards are used all season, white on black, one second:

68 HOURS EARLIER · EARLIER · NOW · MONDAY, 11:00 AM

No dates, no clocks on screen, no "Day 2." The audience should be slightly unmoored in Act One and completely oriented by Act Two.

5. CHARACTERS

VIKRAM ADITYA — 27

Product designer, Vizag. Full name on every document, which he finds mildly embarrassing.

- **Verbal signature:** Telugu, fluent and warm and far too much of it. Over-explains. Apologises pre-emptively. Talks to fill silence and then apologises for talking. His English is good and he uses it sparingly, like a tool he doesn't trust.
- **His Hindi is confidently, catastrophically wrong** and nobody corrects him for sixty episodes.
- **Wound:** he said yes to this the way he has said yes to everything. He did not read the biodata. His father sent a photo and an address. He has never once chosen anything.
- **Arc:** he becomes, for the first time in his life, a person who wants something specific.

The name ladder — he is called, in order: Ep 1 "Vikram Aditya garu" → Ep 14 "Vikram" → Ep 29 mispronounced "Bikram" once, by accident, and he doesn't correct her → Ep 44 "Adi" → Ep 60 "Adi," and by then it is the only thing she calls him.

SHILPAA BOSE — 25

Kolkata. Four months and nine days in Hyderabad. Publishing, remote. Reads on paper.

- **In English:** clipped, efficient, slightly cold, about sixty percent of a person. She hates how she sounds and knows she sounds like that.
- **In Bengali:** fast, funny, filthy, three steps ahead, completely herself.
- **The gap between those two performances is the whole character** and the actor has to play them as two different women who happen to share a body.
- **Her Telugu:** about forty words. Nineteen are food.
- **Wound:** her mother's Telugu family in Kolkata spent twenty-five years calling her the Bengali one. Her father's family spent twenty-five years calling her the South one. She

has never been entirely inside any room she has stood in. When she is alone, she is finally in a room with one person who doesn't have a category for her, and that person is herself, and that is why she talks to herself.

- **Casting note (critical):** she must be genuinely fluent in Bengali. This cannot be phonetically coached. If the Bengali is fake, the series has no floor.

6. THE NINE GAMES

#	Ep	Game	Rule
1	17	TRANSLATE TELEPHONE	A sentence about the other, run through four languages and back. Read the wreckage.
2	24	NOTES APP CONFESSIONAL	Oldest note in your phone. Read it out. No skipping.
3	28	UNTRANSLATABLE	A word from your language with no equivalent. No words allowed to explain it. Act only.
4	33	3 AM LIST	Five people you'd text at 3 AM, in order. Then why number five isn't number one.
5	37	THE MUTTER GAME	She has to say her next three thoughts <i>out loud in English</i> . She lasts eleven seconds.
6	42	THE MUTE HOUR	One hour. No speech in any language. Gestures only.
7	48	CLOSE FRIENDS	Last person you added. Last person you removed.
8	52	DUI HAAT	Palms an inch apart. Mirror. First to touch loses.
9	56	BOLO NA	Whisper a sentence in your own language into the other's ear. They guess the <i>emotion</i> , not the words.

Game 5 is the one that only this version of the series can have. She is asked to externalise her interior monologue in a language that flattens her, and she cannot do it, and what that costs her is the whole second act in ninety seconds.

Game 9 is the near-erotic peak and there is nothing explicit in it. Two people, fully clothed, and a whispered sentence the other cannot understand. It is closer than a kiss. Shoot it in two setups and let the takes run long.

7. THE SIXTY-EPIISODE GRID

ACT ONE — FORTY MINUTES (1–12) · Friday 4:10 – 5:20 PM

Ep	Beat	End Hook
1	MASTER LOOP OPEN. Monday 11 AM, the doorbell. → 68 HOURS EARLIER. He rings. She opens. Face pack. Dye. Nightdress.	"You are early."
2	LOOP A OPEN — her hand on a bathroom door, not opening it. → EARLIER. The negotiation. Forty minutes.	She shuts the bathroom door. First mutter.
3	He waits. Alone in a stranger's hall. Telugu monologue to nobody.	Through the door: a full paragraph he cannot understand.
4	His theory #1: she's on a phone call.	He apologises to the door. She answers in English. Wrong-footed.
5	The timer. She gives him instructions through the door.	"Do not touch the books."
6	He touches nothing and breaks something anyway.	The sound of it. Silence from the bathroom.
7	Her fury, in Bengali, through the door. His confusion, in Telugu.	Neither understands the other and both are completely clear.
8	She opens the door six inches. Face pack half off. Truce.	He starts writing down sounds.
9	THE WORD. She mutters "thakbe?" about a dying plant.	He writes: THOK BEE — ?
10	She emerges. Ready. Composed. Beautiful. English only.	He completely loses his thread.
11	Ten minutes of the most awkward introduction in Telugu history.	His phone rings. Father.
12	LOOP A CLOSE. The flight is cancelled. The airport is shut. Three days. And she drops the English.	Four minutes of fluent Bengali. REVEAL.

ACT TWO — THE WRONG WORDS (13–30) · Friday night – Saturday

Ep	Beat	End Hook
13	LOOP B OPEN — 2 AM balcony, he says a Bengali word wrong to himself. → EARLIER.	She explains, in English, what she is.
14	The hotel is cancelled. He has nowhere. LADDER — "Vikram."	She offers. Three conditions, typed.
15	House tour by gesture. The geyser. Sign language begins.	He calls his mother and lies.
16	Dinner. He doesn't eat fish. Her disbelief.	She makes him something else anyway.
17	GAME 1 — TRANSLATE TELEPHONE.	Her sentence comes back as something true.
18	Night one ends. Two doors.	She googles him. Finds a six-year-old photograph.
19	Saturday. The pidgin starts. Tea takes eleven minutes.	"Bhalo." He says a Bengali word correctly.
20	The diary. She catches him.	Thirty-one words, and she corrects thirty of them.
21	The one she doesn't correct.	She looks at "THOK BEE — thank you (?)" and says nothing.
22	LOOP B CLOSE. What he was doing on the balcony at 2 AM.	He was practising her name.
23	Video call with his mother. She has to perform.	His mother asks a question in Telugu. She answers in Bengali.
24	GAME 2 — NOTES APP CONFESSIONAL.	Her oldest note is Telugu words, dated four months ago.
25	Who the list was for.	"Amar jonno na."
26	It was for her mother. Who died in January.	He has no language for this in any language.
27	So he cooks instead. Badly.	She eats all of it.

28	GAME 3 — UNTRANSLATABLE. "Abhimaan."	He gets it in one. Same word in Telugu.
29	Half a page of shared words. LADDER — "Bikram."	He doesn't correct her. Ever.
30	Saturday night. Closer.	Her father calls. Four minutes of Bengali. "Complicated."

ACT THREE — THROUGH (31–45) • Sunday

Ep	Beat	End Hook
31	LOOP C OPEN — a screaming two-language fight. → EARLIER.	Sunday morning. They stop translating. Neither notices.
32	MUTTER RETURNS BADLY. He repeats one back, decoded wrong, at the worst moment.	She goes white.
33	GAME 4 — 3 AM LIST.	Her list has four people. She stops at four.
34	He uses "thakbe" wrongly to comfort her.	She doesn't correct him.
35	The relative panic. How are the families connected?	Nobody can draw the line.
36	Two hours, a pen, and a calendar taped to the wall.	The line connects. Four generations. Unbroken.
37	GAME 5 — THE MUTTER GAME. Her thoughts, out loud, in English.	Eleven seconds. Then she stops.
38	LOOP C CLOSE. The fight from Ep 31 — in full.	It was about the family tree. It is the funniest scene in the series.
39	Resolved: by marriage, three generations up. No blood.	The relief is out of all proportion and they both see it.
40	Sunday afternoon. Ordinary. Warm. Hour forty-eight.	His charger is in her socket.
41	An email. Bangalore. Eighteen months.	He doesn't tell her.
42	GAME 6 — THE MUTE HOUR.	Fifty-two minutes in, he breaks it, in Telugu, and it isn't a joke.

43	She doesn't ask what it meant.	"Ami bujhechhi."
44	Her own notebook. Telugu words in Bengali script. LADDER — "Adi."	Since Friday night.
45	She tells him she understood the thing he said on Friday.	She says it back. Word-perfect.

ACT FOUR — CHOSEN (46–60) • Sunday night – Monday 11:00 AM

Ep	Beat	End Hook
46	LOOP D OPEN — she is crying, alone, holding his diary. → EARLIER.	Sunday night. He speaks Bengali on purpose.
47	Two hours of preparation for four sentences.	She goes very quiet.
48	GAME 7 — CLOSE FRIENDS.	The last account she removed was her mother's.
49	Grief, with no line about grief. Two minutes of him saying nothing.	Her hand on the top of his head.
50	The mutters he has collected. Ninety-one. He reads them out.	She hears her own three days, from the outside.
51	LOOP D CLOSE. Why she was crying.	Word thirty-one. He finds out what it means. He says nothing.
52	GAME 8 — DUI HAAT.	Twenty-two minutes. Neither touches. Neither wins.
53	Midnight. The flights resume. Eleven hours.	Neither of them wants the version that happens tomorrow.
54	The real conversation. In English, because she chooses the harder one.	"Would you pick me?"
55	He answers in Telugu, at length, and she lets him.	She doesn't ask for a translation.
56	GAME 9 — BOLO NA. Two whispers. Unsubtitled.	She doesn't guess. She stays there.
57	4:40 AM. She falls asleep on his shoulder.	He doesn't move for seventy minutes.

58	Monday 7 AM. Hiding a weekend.	She puts his diary in her drawer, not his bag.
59	MASTER LOOP CLOSE. 10:50 AM. The doorbell. And then, past it.	"Thakbe?"
60	The answer. The families. The decision.	FLASH-FORWARD: fourteen months later.

8. THE ENDING AND WHY IT IS NOT A CLIFFHANGER

They say yes. Both of them. On screen, in Episode 60, with both families in the room.

This is deliberate. A "will they / won't they" finale would be the fourth time your channel has done that, and this series has earned something better: a couple who choose each other in full knowledge of exactly how difficult it is going to be.

Then the last thirty seconds.

Cut to **FOURTEEN MONTHS LATER.** The same flat, redressed. Married. An ordinary morning. And one small, entirely undramatic moment that tells you the thing neither of them thought about while they were falling in love over three rainy days.

The season does not end on a question about whether they'll be together. It ends on a question about **what being together is actually going to cost.**

That is Season 2, and it is a much better season than a will-they-won't-they one.

9. BUDGET

Sixty episodes is roughly 135 minutes of finished content. The honest number at four shoot days:

Head	₹
2 artists (4 days) — negotiate a series rate, not a day rate	34,000
DOP + camera/lens kit (4 days)	20,000
Lighting — 1 LED + practicals + bounce	5,000
Lav x2 + boom + recordist	10,000

Flat location (4 days)	7,000
Makeup: face pack, dye continuity, the transformation in Ep 10	4,000
Art: diary, notebooks, two phones, food, dressing	3,000
Food, fuel, consumables	7,000
Editor — 60 cuts + 2 compilations	14,000
Bengali–English subtitling, burned in, 60 episodes	6,000
Music — two beds	4,000
Thumbnails, titles, posters	4,000
Total	1,18,000

My recommendation: shoot it as two blocks of thirty and fund the second from the first. Episode 30 ends on her father's call and "Complicated" — a real break point. Two shoots of two days each, ₹59,000 apiece, and the second one is paid for by the first.

Where not to cut: the subtitling line and the makeup line. The face pack and dye have to look real and have to hold continuity across eleven episodes shot out of order, and every frame of Bengali is unreadable without proper subs.

Non-linear production note: shoot in scene blocks, never in episode order. The flash-forward at the top of Episode 31 and the scene it comes from in Episode 38 are **the same take, split in the edit**. Same for Eps 1/59, 2/12, 13/22, 46/51. Shoot each of those once, cut it twice. That is five setups saved and, more importantly, it is the only way the match is exact.

SEASON 1 — SCRIPT

Format note. Bengali is written in Roman Bengali with the English subtitle in square brackets. Telugu is written in Roman Telugu with the subtitle in brackets where meaning matters to a non-Telugu viewer. English is plain. The brackets are the burned-in subtitle — the actors never see them and the characters never know they exist.

Mutters are marked (MUTTER) in the action line. She is always turned away, always mid-task, never performing.

ACT ONE — FORTY MINUTES

INT. FLAT – MONDAY 11:00 AM – EPISODE 1

COLD OPEN.

A hall. Two chairs pulled out. Tea things laid.

SHILPAA stands with her hand on the front door latch. She has not opened it.

VIKRAM ADITYA stands four feet behind her.

The doorbell rings.

Neither moves.

From outside, muffled — two voices. One speaking Bengali. One speaking Telugu. Both at once. Neither understanding the other. Extremely cheerful.

Shilpaa turns her head and looks back at him.

He looks at her.

Twelve seconds.

The doorbell rings again.

CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD: 68 HOURS EARLIER

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY 4:10 PM – CONTINUOUS

DOORBELL.

A flat that belongs to one person. Books in stacks. One mug on the rack. A dying plant on the balcony.

SHILPAA, 25, comes out of the bathroom at speed.

She is in a nightdress. There is a green face pack drying in patches on her cheeks and forehead. Her hair is clipped up under a plastic shower cap, dye visibly working underneath. One rubber glove on.

She looks through the peephole.

She goes very still.

She looks at the clock. 4:10.

SHILPAA (MUTTER — to herself, turning away from the door) Na na na na. Chaar-ta chollish. Paanch-ta bola chhilo. Paanch-ta. [No no no no. It's four forty. They said five. Five.]

She looks down at herself.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (MUTTER) Ami ekhon ki korbo? Ami to ekta bhoot. [What do I do now? I'm a ghost.]

DOORBELL. Again.

She takes the glove off.

She opens the door.

VIKRAM ADITYA, 27, is standing there. Ironed shirt. Gift box. Trolley bag. Shoes he has polished.

He opens his mouth.

He looks at her.

He closes his mouth.

A beat.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) You are early.

CUT

EPISODE 1 END

INT. BATHROOM DOOR – EPISODE 2

COLD OPEN — LOOP A.

A bathroom door, closed.

A hand on the handle. Shilpaa's. Her face is clean. Her hair is done. She is fully dressed and ready.

She does not open the door.

She stands there with her hand on the handle for eight seconds.

She lowers her hand.

TITLE CARD: EARLIER

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY 4:11 PM – CONTINUOUS

The doorway. The face pack. Both of them frozen.

VIKRAM Namaskaram andi. Nen —

SHILPAA Five o'clock.

VIKRAM Andi?

SHILPAA They said five o'clock.

VIKRAM Flight early landed andi. Cab kuda fast ochindi. Nen airport lo kurcholeka — [The flight landed early. The cab was fast too. I couldn't sit at the airport—]

She does not follow any of it. She holds up a hand.

SHILPAA English?

VIKRAM Ah — yes. Yes. I am early. Sorry.

SHILPAA Yes.

She looks at the clock on the wall behind her.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) I need forty minutes.

VIKRAM Forty?

SHILPAA (pointing at her own face) This. And this.

(pointing at the cap)

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Cannot stop. Timer.

VIKRAM Andi, nen bayata wait chestha —

SHILPAA Sit.

She points at the sofa.

He sits.

She walks to the bathroom.

At the door she stops and says, entirely to herself, half under her breath, with her back to him:

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (MUTTER) Chhele ta dekhte bhaloi. Kintu ami ekta shobji-r moto dekhte lagchi. Bhogoban. [The boy's good-looking, actually. But I look like a vegetable. God.]

The bathroom door shuts.

Vikram sits in a stranger's hall holding a gift box.

VIKRAM (to himself) Adi enti?

CUT

EPISODE 2 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY – EPISODE 3

He is alone in the hall.

He puts the gift box on the table. Moves it. Moves it back.

He looks around. Books. A lot of books. A dead-ish plant on the balcony.

He does what he does, which is talk.

VIKRAM (to nobody, in Telugu) Naa peru Vikram Aditya. Nen Vizag nunchi vachanu. Naaku design work. [My name is Vikram Aditya. I've come from Vizag. I do design work.]

He is rehearsing.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Ledu. Adi baaledu. Malli. [No. That's bad. Again.]

He clears his throat.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Namaskaram. Nen Vikram.

From behind the bathroom door — water running, and under it, a voice.

Not talking to him. Talking to itself. Fast. Continuous.

SHILPAA (O.S.) (MUTTER) Ki obostha. Ekta lok boshe achhe amar drawing room-e ar ami ekhane mukh-e shobji niye darie achhi. Baba jodi janto. Baba bolechhilo paanch-ta. Amar mone achhe. Ami likhe rekhechhila. [What a situation. There's a man sitting in my drawing room and I'm standing here with a vegetable on my face. If Dad knew. Dad said five. I remember. I wrote it down.]

Vikram turns his head toward the door.

He listens.

He cannot identify a single word of it.

VIKRAM (quietly) Idi ye bhasha? [What language is that?]

CUT

EPISODE 3 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY – EPISODE 4

He listens for another twenty seconds.

The voice keeps going.

He arrives at his first theory and it is entirely reasonable.

VIKRAM (to himself) Phone lo matladutundi. Ade. [She's on the phone. That's it.]

He relaxes.

Then, being polite, he raises his voice toward the door.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Andi! Meeru phone lo unte nen bayata veltha! Naaku problem ledu!
[Ma'am! If you're on the phone I'll wait outside! No problem for me!]

The voice stops.

A pause.

SHILPAA (O.S.) What?

VIKRAM Phone! Phone andi!

SHILPAA (O.S.) No phone.

VIKRAM Andi, nen vinnanu —

SHILPAA (O.S.) No phone. Sit.

Silence.

Vikram looks at the door.

He looks at the sofa.

He sits.

VIKRAM (to himself) Aithe evaru undi lopala? [Then who's in there?]

CUT

EPISODE 4 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY – EPISODE 5

Twelve minutes in.

He has now examined everything in the hall without touching any of it. This takes a physical restraint that is funny to watch.

SHILPAA (O.S.) Hello?

VIKRAM Andi!

SHILPAA (O.S.) Water is in kitchen. Fridge.

VIKRAM Thank you andi.

SHILPAA (O.S.) Do not touch the books.

VIKRAM Enti?

SHILPAA (O.S.) Books. Do not touch.

VIKRAM Sare andi. Nen muttanu. [Fine. I won't touch.]

A pause.

SHILPAA (O.S.) (MUTTER, from inside, not for him) Keno je bollam. Ekhon o oigulo-tei hath debe. Manush er shobhab. Bolle na korle kori. [Why did I even say it. Now he'll definitely touch them. That's human nature. You tell someone not to, they do.]

Vikram, in the hall, hears the muttering start again.

He looks at the door with growing concern.

He looks at the books.

He very deliberately moves his chair so that his back is to them.

CUT

EPISODE 5 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY – EPISODE 6

Eighteen minutes.

He gets up to get water.

He walks past the shelf. His elbow is nowhere near it.

His trolley bag handle, which he is dragging because he doesn't know where to put it, catches the leg of a small side table.

A ceramic something goes off the edge.

He lunges.

He gets a hand under it.

It bounces off his palm and hits the floor and breaks cleanly into three pieces.

The sound is enormous.

Vikram stands very still, holding nothing, looking at the floor.

From the bathroom: complete silence.

The water stops running.

VIKRAM (very quietly) Ayyo.

Nothing from the bathroom.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Andi?

Nothing.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Andi, nen —

The bathroom door does not open.

But from behind it, at volume, comes an absolute torrent of Bengali.

CUT

EPISODE 6 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY – EPISODE 7

He stands in the wreckage of a ceramic bowl being shouted at in a language he has never heard, through a closed door, by a woman he has known for nineteen minutes.

SHILPAA (O.S.) (MUTTER, but loud now, furious, to herself) Ami bolechhilam! Ami boshte bolechhilam! Ekta jinis! Ekta jinis chhilo Ma-r! Ki bhabe ekta manush ekta ghor-e kuri minute boshe theke ekta jinis bhange?! [I said! I said sit! One thing! There was one thing that was

Mum's! How does a person sit in a room for twenty minutes and break something?!

Vikram, hands raised, addressing the door.

VIKRAM Andi, nen sorry cheptunna! Nen muttanu andi! Naa bag thaggindi! Nen pattukovadaniki try chesa! [Ma'am, I'm saying sorry! I didn't touch it! My bag hit it! I tried to catch it!]

SHILPAA (O.S.) (MUTTER) Ki bolchhe? Kichhu bujhchhi na. [What is he saying? I don't understand a thing.]

VIKRAM Nen deenni repair chestha andi! Nen manchi gum techhi! [I'll repair it! I'll get good glue!]

SHILPAA (O.S.) (MUTTER) Aro bolchhe. Ekhono bolchhe. [He's still talking. He's still going.]

They continue for another fifteen seconds — two people in complete emotional agreement, expressing it in two mutually unintelligible languages, at increasing volume, through a wooden door.

Then both stop at the same moment.

Silence.

VIKRAM (quietly, in English) I am sorry.

A long pause.

SHILPAA (O.S.) Okay.

CUT

EPISODE 7 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY – EPISODE 8

Twenty-six minutes.

The bathroom door opens six inches.

Shilpaa's face appears in the gap. The face pack is half off — clean on one side, still green on the other. The cap is still on.

She looks at the floor. At the three pieces.

She looks at him.

He is holding all three pieces very carefully in both hands, like an injured bird.

She looks at his face.

Something in her gives up.

SHILPAA It was a bowl.

VIKRAM Avunu.

SHILPAA I have four.

VIKRAM Andi?

SHILPAA (holding up four fingers) Four. This is number four.

He does not entirely believe her and she does not entirely mean it, and both of those things are visible.

VIKRAM Nen sorry andi.

SHILPAA Okay.

She starts to close the door.

Then stops.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Fourteen minutes.

The door closes.

Vikram puts the three pieces on the table, arranged in the shape of the bowl.

Then he sits back down, takes out a small diary from his laptop bag, opens it at the back page, and uncaps a pen.

He listens.

Through the door, the voice starts up again.

He writes down a sound.

CUT

EPISODE 8 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY – EPISODE 9

He has four sounds written down. All of them are wrong.

"KI HOLO" "BAAJEY" "EI RE" "AMAR"

He sounds them out under his breath, silently, moving his lips.

From the bathroom, the shower stops.

Footsteps.

The door opens — and she comes out, wrapped in a towel over the nightdress, hair down and wet, face clean, heading straight past him to the balcony without looking at him.

She stops at the balcony door.

The plant.

She crouches down in front of it. Touches a leaf.

And says, entirely to herself, quiet, the way you say things to a plant:

SHILPAA (MUTTER) Ei. Ei je. Thakbe? [Hey. Listen. Will you stay?]

She touches the soil.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (MUTTER) Aar ek shopta. Please. [One more week. Please.]

She gets up and walks back to the bedroom and the door closes.

Vikram, on the sofa, writes it down.

"THOK BEE — ?"

He looks at the question mark.

CUT

EPISODE 9 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY 4:52 PM – EPISODE 10

The bedroom door opens.

Shilpaa comes out.

Saree, or a good kurta — whatever the actor is most at home in. Hair done. Face done. Earrings. Entirely, completely put together.

She is a different person from the one who opened the door forty-two minutes ago.

Vikram stands up.

He gets about a third of the way through standing up and then just — stops, mid-motion, for

a second, before completing it.

She sees it. She files it. She gives no sign.

SHILPAA Sorry for waiting.

VIKRAM Andi —

He has entirely lost the speech he rehearsed.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Nen... namaskaram.

SHILPAA Namaskar.

VIKRAM Naa peru Vikram Aditya.

SHILPAA I know.

VIKRAM Avunu. Obviously. Sorry.

She sits down opposite him.

She arranges herself with tremendous care.

SHILPAA Tea?

VIKRAM Ah — no. Thank you. Thanks.

SHILPAA Okay.

A silence of exceptional quality.

CUT

EPISODE 10 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY – EPISODE 11

Ten minutes of the worst introduction ever conducted.

VIKRAM Andi, meeru... work?

SHILPAA Publishing. From home.

VIKRAM Ohh! Books! Anduke ikkada books —

He gestures at the shelf and then remembers the bowl and lowers his hand.

SHILPAA Yes.

VIKRAM Nen design chestanu andi. Product design. Apps, websites. [I do design. Product design. Apps, websites.]

SHILPAA Slowly.

VIKRAM Sorry. Design. I do design.

SHILPAA Okay.

VIKRAM Meeru Hyderabad lo entha kaalam?

She looks at him blankly.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) How long? Hyderabad?

SHILPAA Four months.

VIKRAM Ohh! Naalugu nelalu! Kotha ne!

SHILPAA Yes.

VIKRAM Meeku Hyderabad nachinda?

She doesn't follow.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) You like? Hyderabad?

Shilpaa considers this question properly, which is more than it deserves.

SHILPAA It is a city.

VIKRAM (laughing, delighted) Adi ne! Adi ne correct answer andi!

She does not know why he is laughing but the laughing is nice.

She almost smiles.

His phone rings.

Screen: **NANNA.**

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Sorry andi. Ma nanna.

He answers.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Nanna? ... Enti? ... Eppudu?

CUT

EPISODE 11 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY – EPISODE 12

LOOP A CLOSES.

He lowers the phone.

VIKRAM Andi.

SHILPAA Yes?

VIKRAM Ma vaallu Kolkata lo unnaru. Mee nanna ni kalavadaniki vellaru. Flight cancel aindi.
[My family are in Kolkata. They went to meet your father. The flight is cancelled.]

She has followed about four words.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Kolkata. Airport. Cancel.

Shilpaa's face changes.

She grabs her own phone off the table.

She opens it. Scrolls. Finds it.

She reads.

CYCLONE — KOLKATA AIRPORT CLOSED — ALL FLIGHTS SUSPENDED 72 HOURS

She reads it twice.

And then the English goes.

All of it. In one second.

SHILPAA (full Bengali, fast, not to him at all) Chhiyattor ghonta? Baba okhane? Baba-r to blood pressure achhe, Baba airport-e tin din bosbe ki kore, ar Mashi? Mashi-r hnatu-r problem — ar amar ekhane ei chhele — [Seventy-two hours? Dad's there? Dad has blood pressure, how will Dad sit in an airport for three days, and Aunty? Aunty's knee — and here I've got this boy—]

She stops.

She looks up.

Vikram Aditya is staring at her.

Four minutes of fluent, rapid, completely fluent Bengali.

VIKRAM Andi.

SHILPAA (still in Bengali, quieter) Ki?

VIKRAM Idi... idi ne kada. Bathroom lo. [This... this is it. In the bathroom.]

He points at the bathroom door. Then at her.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Idi meere.

Shilpaa realises what she has done.

SHILPAA Ohh.

CUT

EPISODE 12 END

ACT TWO — THE WRONG WORDS

EXT. BALCONY – NIGHT – EPISODE 13

COLD OPEN — LOOP B.

2 AM. Dark. Rain off the railing.

Vikram Aditya, alone, at the grill.

He is holding his diary. He is not looking at it.

He says something in Bengali, quietly, to nobody.

VIKRAM Shil... paa. Shilpaa.

He shakes his head.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Ledu. Adi kaadu. [No. That's not it.]

He tries again, differently.

TITLE CARD: EARLIER

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY EVENING – CONTINUOUS

She has the phone out, translator open, and she is explaining herself in English, which she hates, which is why it is short.

SHILPAA My father is Bengali. Kolkata. I was born there. I live there. My whole life.

VIKRAM Aithe mee amma —

SHILPAA My mother. Her family is Telugu. They went to Kolkata. Long back. Before she was born.

VIKRAM Ohh.

SHILPAA Mother's mother's family. Your family. Somewhere.

She makes a vague, helpless gesture at the enormity of the connection.

VIKRAM Meeku Telugu raadha?

SHILPAA Little.

VIKRAM Entha little?

SHILPAA (holding thumb and finger a centimetre apart) Little.

VIKRAM Andi, naaku evaru cheppaledu. [Nobody told me.]

SHILPAA Nobody told me also.

VIKRAM Enti?

SHILPAA My father said — "Telugu boy. Nice family." That is all.

VIKRAM Ma nanna kuda ade cheppadu. "Manchi ammayi. Manchi family." Anthe. [My father said the same. Nice girl, nice family. That's all.]

They look at each other.

Two people who have been sent into a room with no information by two men who have known each other for four weeks.

CUT

EPISODE 13 END

INT. FLAT – FRIDAY NIGHT – EPISODE 14

He is on the phone in the corner, voice low.

VIKRAM Nanna, hotel? ... Cancel chesara? ... Nanna, nen ekkada untanu? ... Nanna — [Dad, the hotel? ... You cancelled it? ... Dad, where do I stay? ... Dad—]

He hangs up.

He stands with his back to her for slightly too long.

Then he turns around with an enormous, failing, cheerful face.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) No problem andi. No problem.

He types. Shows her.

"Hotel is cancelled. It's fine. I will find something."

She reads it.

She looks at the window. Rain, hard now.

She looks at the clock. 6:40 PM.

She looks at him standing by his trolley bag with the polished shoes and the gift box he has still not put down.

SHILPAA (MUTTER, turning away, picking up a cup that doesn't need picking up) Ei bristi-te ekta chhele ke ber kore dile ami ki hobo. Baba jodi shone. Ma jodi shunto. [If I put a boy out in this rain, what does that make me. If Dad hears. If Mum had heard.]

She puts the cup down.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) There is a second room.

VIKRAM Andi —

SHILPAA Three conditions.

She types them. Turns the phone.

"1. That door closes at 11. 2. Do not touch the books. 3. Do not tell anyone. Not your mother. Not my father. Nobody."

He reads it.

VIKRAM Thank you, Shilpaa garu.

SHILPAA Shilpaa.

VIKRAM Shilpaa.

SHILPAA And you?

VIKRAM Vikram.

CUT

EPISODE 14 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 15

The house tour. Entirely in gesture.

Kitchen — she points, thumbs up.

Her bedroom — flat horizontal hand. Final.

Second room — nod.

Bathroom — she opens her mouth, and stops, because this one requires explaining and there is no gesture for it.

SHILPAA Geyser.

She mimes a knob turning. Then a wait. Then holds up ten fingers.

VIKRAM Padi nimishalu.

She mimes hot water. Then mimes it going suddenly cold. Then mimes screaming.

He laughs. First real laugh.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Artham aindi andi.

She gives him a thumbs up. He returns it.

AGREED SIGNS #1 and #2, established.

TIME CUT.

The second room. Door open. Phone to ear.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Amma. ... Ledu amma, hotel bagundi. ... Chala pedda room amma. ... Meals kuda unnayi. ... Amma, nen tinna. [Mum. ... No Mum, the hotel's fine. ... Very big room. ... Meals included. ... Mum, I've eaten.]

Shilpaa passes the doorway with a basket of laundry.

She hears the tone, not the words, and she knows exactly what he is doing because she has done it.

SHILPAA (MUTTER, walking on) Oi to. Ek-i mithye. Duto alada bhasha-y. [There it is. The same lie. In two different languages.]

CUT

EPISODE 15 END

INT. KITCHEN – NIGHT – EPISODE 16

She cooks. Fast, confident, entirely at home.

She serves two plates. Rice. A fish curry.

She sits. She looks up.

He is looking at the fish the way a man looks at a live animal he has been handed.

SHILPAA Ki holo? [What is it?]

VIKRAM Andi... naaku...

He types.

"I don't eat fish."

She reads it.

SHILPAA What?

VIKRAM Sorry andi —

SHILPAA (full Bengali, appalled, at speed) Mach khao na? Keno? Ekta manush ki bhabe mach khay na? Ami tin ghonta — [You don't eat fish? Why? How does a human being not eat fish? I spent three hours—]

VIKRAM Andi. Andi. Nen sorry cheptunna.

She puts her hands over her face. Takes them away.

She stands, takes his plate, and goes back to the kitchen.

SHILPAA (MUTTER, from the kitchen, banging things) Mach khay na. Bhogoban. Ami ekhon dim bhajbo. Ekta purush manush er jonno dim bhajchhi. Chollish minute poreo. [Doesn't eat fish. God. Now I'm frying an egg. I'm frying an egg for a grown man. Forty minutes later and I'm still at it.]

Six minutes later a plate lands in front of him. Rice, dal, a fried egg, potatoes.

She sits back down and eats her own, pointedly.

VIKRAM Thank you.

SHILPAA Hmm.

CUT

EPISODE 16 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 17

GAME 1 — TRANSLATE TELEPHONE

She types the rule and shows him.

"You have said 'no problem' eleven times in four hours. New game. Write one sentence about me. Your language. We run it through four languages and back."

VIKRAM Idi enduku?

SHILPAA Because I am angry about the fish.

He types in Telugu. Turns the screen away. Runs it.

Telugu → Japanese → French → Arabic → Bengali → English.

She reads the output aloud.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) "She is cooking inside the anger of the fish, but the kindness is not a small thing."

VIKRAM Adi nen rasindi kaadu!

SHILPAA What did you write?

He types the original into English.

"She got angry about the fish but she still made me something else."

She reads it.

She doesn't say anything for a second.

SHILPAA My turn.

She types in Bengali. Runs it.

He reads the English wreckage aloud.

VIKRAM "The man is too much polite and it is the loneliness of the polite man."

He stops.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Meeru asalu enti rasaru?

She takes the phone back and deletes it before he can scroll.

SHILPAA Game over.

CUT

EPISODE 17 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 18

11:40 PM.

Both in the hall, at opposite ends, both on laptops, both pretending to work.

She closes hers first.

SHILPAA Good night.

VIKRAM Good night andi.

She goes to her door. Stops. Turns.

SHILPAA Tomorrow. Fish. No.

VIKRAM (laughing) No fish.

SHILPAA No fish.

She goes in.

He sits alone in the hall, still smiling.

He opens the diary. Writes:

"MACH — fish" "NA — no"

CUT TO:

INT. SHILPAA'S ROOM – CONTINUOUS

She is on her bed with her phone.

She types into a search bar: **Vikram Aditya Vizag design**

She scrolls.

LinkedIn. A portfolio. A photograph from a college event, six years old.

She looks at that one for a while.

SHILPAA (MUTTER, to herself, in the dark) Chhele ta beshi bhalo. Seta-i problem. [The boy is too nice. That's the problem.]

She puts the phone down.

CUT

EPISODE 18 END

INT. KITCHEN – MORNING – EPISODE 19

Saturday. The tea negotiation.

She holds up a packet. Points at it. Points at him. Raises eyebrows.

VIKRAM Avunu. Tea.

She fills a pan.

He points at the sugar. Holds up two fingers.

She nods. Then holds up her own hand — zero — and points at herself.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Zero ah? Chakkerale daa?

She shakes her head. Makes a face.

He mimes disbelief. She mimes that his two sugars will kill him. He mimes that her zero sugar is a tragedy.

Forty seconds of this, no words, completely legible.

AGREED SIGNS #3–#6 established: little/lots, yes/no, wait, and a flat palm meaning "don't."

They sit at the counter.

SHILPAA Bhalo? [Good?]

VIKRAM Bhalo.

Her head comes up.

SHILPAA You said "bhalo."

VIKRAM Avunu! Nen rasukunna!

He is extremely pleased with himself.

SHILPAA (MUTTER, looking into her cup) Uff. Eta ekta problem hote cholechhe. [Uff. This is going to become a problem.]

CUT

EPISODE 19 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 20

She comes out and he doesn't hear her.

He is at the dining table with the diary open, sounding out words under his breath.

VIKRAM Ki ho-lo. Ei re. Ba-jey. Amar.

SHILPAA What are you doing?

He shuts the diary like a schoolboy.

VIKRAM Emi ledu.

SHILPAA Show.

VIKRAM Andi, adi —

She holds out her hand. Flat. Waiting.

He gives it to her.

She opens it at the back.

Thirty-one words. Phonetic. Almost all misspelt.

She reads down the list.

She starts laughing at word four and does not stop until word twenty.

SHILPAA "BAJEY." Yes. This is correct. You wrote this from the bathroom?

VIKRAM Avunu.

SHILPAA I said this about you.

VIKRAM Artham enti?

SHILPAA (a beat) It means "nice."

VIKRAM Ohh!

SHILPAA (MUTTER, turning away) Bajey mane bajey. Kintu thak. [Bajey means rubbish. But let it go.]

CUT

EPISODE 20 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 21

She is still reading the list.

She reaches word thirty-one.

SHILPAA "THOK BEE."

She looks at it.

"THOK BEE — ?"

She looks up at him.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Where did you get this one?

VIKRAM Balcony daggara andi. Meeru aa mokka daggara kurchunnaru. [By the balcony. You were crouching by that plant.]

He mimes it — crouching, touching a leaf.

Shilpaa remembers.

She looks back at the page.

She picks up his pen.

She corrects word thirty-two. And thirty-three. And every word after it.

She does not touch word thirty-one.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Andi. Aa okkati?

SHILPAA Later.

VIKRAM Enduku later?

SHILPAA (MUTTER, closing the diary and handing it back) Karon ami bolte parbo na. Ekhono na. [Because I can't say it. Not yet.]

VIKRAM Enti?

SHILPAA Later.

CUT

EPISODE 21 END

EXT. BALCONY – NIGHT – EPISODE 22

LOOP B CLOSES.

TITLE CARD: NOW

2 AM. The same frame as Episode 13.

Vikram Aditya alone at the railing, diary in hand.

VIKRAM Shil... paa. Shilpaa.

He shakes his head.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Ledu. Adi kaadu.

He tries again. Different stress.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Shil-paa.

Behind him, the balcony door slides.

He turns around fast.

Shilpaa is in the doorway.

Neither of them says anything.

SHILPAA That is my name.

VIKRAM Avunu.

SHILPAA You are practising my name.

VIKRAM Andi, nen —

SHILPAA Why?

He considers lying. He is bad at it.

VIKRAM Endukante nen dhanni thappu ga anta andi. Mee nanna repu phone chesthadu. Nen dhanni correct ga cheppali. [Because I say it wrong. Your father will call tomorrow. I want to say it correctly.]

He types it. She reads it.

She reads it twice.

SHILPAA Shil-paa. Not Shilpa. Two a's.

VIKRAM Shilpaa.

SHILPAA Better.

She comes and stands at the railing. Not close. Not far.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (MUTTER) Keu amar naam niye ei porishrom kore ni. Kokhono na.
[Nobody has ever taken this much trouble over my name. Not once.]

VIKRAM Enti andi?

SHILPAA Nothing.

CUT

EPISODE 22 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 23

Saturday. His phone buzzes. Video call. **AMMA.**

He panics.

VIKRAM Andi! Andi! Ma amma!

He mimes: phone, face, his mother, disaster.

Shilpaa understands instantly and starts fixing her hair, which tells us something no line could.

He answers. Holds the phone up.

We never see the screen.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Amma! ... Avunu, nen bagunna.

A pause.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) (to Shilpaa, urgently) Amma. Amma!

She comes and sits beside him. Close. In frame.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Amma, idi Shilpaa.

SHILPAA Namaskar.

We hear nothing, but we watch her face as his mother talks at length, warmly, in Telugu, to a girl who understands none of it.

Shilpaa keeps smiling. Nods at the right moments. Her eyes flick to Vikram twice.

Then a pause. His mother has asked a question.

Vikram freezes.

Shilpaa waits. Then answers in Bengali, warmly, at length.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Aunty, apnar chhele khub bhodro. Ekta jinis bhengechhe, kintu seta ami kichhu mone korini. Ami rannna korechhi, uni kheyechhen — mach chhara. [Aunty, your son is very well-mannered. He broke one thing, but I didn't mind. I cooked, he ate — minus the fish.]

Vikram stares at her in total terror.

A pause on the other end.

Then, clearly audible:

AMMA (V.O.) Chala baagundi ma.

The call ends.

They both exhale.

VIKRAM Meeru emi cheppar—

SHILPAA What did you—

They both stop.

Neither will ever find out.

CUT

EPISODE 23 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 24

GAME 2 — NOTES APP CONFESSIONAL

"Notes app. Scroll to the bottom. Oldest note. Read it. No skipping."

VIKRAM Idi danger andi.

SHILPAA Yes.

He goes first, because he always goes first.

He scrolls a long way.

VIKRAM Rendu vela irvai.

He reads it out.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) "Things to say in the interview. One. I am a team player. Two. My weakness is that I care too much."

Shilpaa puts her face in her hands.

SHILPAA No. No no no no.

VIKRAM Nen irvai okka lo unna andi!

SHILPAA That is not an excuse.

Her turn.

She scrolls. Further. Further.

She stops.

She looks at the screen for a moment.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (MUTTER) Na. Eta na. [No. Not this one.]

VIKRAM Rules andi.

SHILPAA Yes. I know.

She turns the phone around instead.

He reads it.

A list, in Bengali script, which he cannot read — but the format is unmistakable. Two columns. Thirty or forty lines.

VIKRAM Idi enti?

She types the translation.

"Telugu words. With Bengali meanings."

He looks at the date stamp.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Idi naalugu nelala kindata. [This is four months ago.]

She nods.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Ee sambandam rendu vaaralu kindata modalaindi. [This alliance started two weeks ago.]

She nods again.

CUT

EPISODE 24 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 25

VIKRAM Aithe idi enduku?

He types it.

She types back.

"Not for you."

VIKRAM Mari evari kosam?

"Not for me either."

He looks up.

She is looking at the window.

SHILPAA Ma.

VIKRAM Mee amma ah?

SHILPAA Ha. Ma.

VIKRAM Mee ammake Telugu vachu kada?

She understands "Telugu" and "amma" and builds the rest.

SHILPAA Ma... Telugu... little.

She holds her thumb and finger a centimetre apart.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (sliding into Bengali without noticing) Ma chhoto chhilo jekhoni Kolkata chole ashe. Dida Bangla bolto. Baba Bangla. Shob Bangla. Ma-r Telugu... hariye gelo. [Mum was small when they moved to Kolkata. Grandma spoke Bengali. Dad, Bengali. Everything Bengali. Mum's Telugu... got lost.]

Vikram understands maybe four words and all of the meaning.

VIKRAM Ante... meeru nerchukuntunnaru. Mee amma kosam. [So... you were learning. For your mother.]

He doesn't type it. He just says it.

She doesn't need it typed.

SHILPAA Ha.

VIKRAM Aame ippudu ekkada?

Shilpaa understands "ekkada."

SHILPAA January.

CUT

EPISODE 25 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 26

Neither of them moves for a while.

He starts to type something. Deletes it. Starts again. Deletes it.

He puts the phone down.

VIKRAM Andi.

SHILPAA Hmm.

He has nothing. He has three languages and none of them has anything in it for this.

VIKRAM Naaku ee bhasha ledu andi. [I don't have the language for this.]

She watches him struggle.

SHILPAA Bolte hobe na. [You don't have to say it.]

He doesn't understand the words.

He understands the tone completely.

He nods.

She picks up her book and goes to the balcony and sits with her back to the door and does not read it.

VIKRAM (MUTTER's equivalent — his own, quietly, to nobody, in the hall) Naaku emi cheyyalo teliyadu. Nen okka saari kuda evariki emi cheyyaledu. Nen andariki "sare" antanu. Anthe. [I don't know what to do. I've never done anything for anybody. I say okay to everyone. That's all.]

He looks at the kitchen.

CUT

EPISODE 26 END

INT. KITCHEN – EVENING – EPISODE 27

He is cooking.

It is not going well.

There is smoke. There is a pan doing something a pan should not do. He is consulting his phone with one hand and holding a lid like a shield with the other.

Shilpaa appears in the doorway.

SHILPAA What are you doing?!

VIKRAM Nen vanta chestunna andi!

SHILPAA Why?!

VIKRAM Endukante meeru roju chestunnaru!

She moves to intervene. He blocks the doorway with the lid.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) No. No no no. Nen chestha. Kurchondi.

He points at the chair. Firmly.

She looks at him.

She sits.

SHILPAA (MUTTER, sitting down) Ei prothom keu amake ranna ghor theke ber kore dilo. Ar ami kichhu bolte parchhi na. Karon amar bhalo lagchhe. [That's the first time anyone has thrown me out of a kitchen. And I can't say anything. Because I like it.]

TIME CUT.

The plate arrives. An omelette, a sort of dal, and rice that has clearly had an eventful life.

She looks at it.

She looks at him, wrecked, with flour on his shirt for reasons that will never be explained because there is no flour in any of these dishes.

She eats it. All of it.

VIKRAM Baaledu kada.

SHILPAA Very bad.

VIKRAM Artham aindi.

She keeps eating.

SHILPAA But I ate everything.

CUT

EPISODE 27 END

INT. FLAT – EVENING – EPISODE 28

GAME 3 — UNTRANSLATABLE

"A word from my language with no word in yours. You guess. I cannot use words. Only acting."

VIKRAM Idi impossible andi.

SHILPAA Yes.

She stands. Moves to the middle of the hall.

She thinks.

Then she performs it.

She turns her back. Arms folded. Chin lifted. Shoulders set.

Then — she glances back, just once, a flick of the eyes over the shoulder, and away again immediately.

Then she waits, very still, with her whole body aimed at being noticed and her face aimed at the wall.

She holds it.

Vikram watches.

His face changes.

VIKRAM Abhimaanam.

She turns around.

SHILPAA What did you say?

VIKRAM Abhimaanam. Telugu lo andi.

SHILPAA Abhimaan?

VIKRAM Abhimaanam!

SHILPAA One guess. First time.

She sits down heavily, delighted and slightly cheated.

CUT

EPISODE 28 END

INT. FLAT – EVENING – EPISODE 29

He takes the pen and the diary and turns to a clean page.

He writes **ABHIMAANAM**, and under it **ABHIMAAN**.

VIKRAM Idi okkate andi.

SHILPAA Ek-i. Same one.

They look at the two words on the page.

She takes the pen from him.

She writes a Bengali word. Says it.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Mon.

VIKRAM Manasu!

SHILPAA Ma?

VIKRAM Amma!

SHILPAA Baba?

VIKRAM Nanna. Adi different.

SHILPAA (disappointed) Achha.

They fill half a page. By the end there are nineteen words and they are still arguing about "ghor."

She sits back, satisfied, and says, without thinking:

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Bikram, aro ekta bolo. [Bikram, say another one.]

He stops.

VIKRAM Bikram?

SHILPAA (not hearing it) Hmm?

He opens his mouth to correct her.

He doesn't.

VIKRAM Emi ledu. Cheppandi.

He will never correct it. Not once, for thirty-one more episodes.

CUT

EPISODE 29 END

EXT. BALCONY – NIGHT – EPISODE 30

Saturday, midnight.

They are on the balcony. The gap between them is noticeably smaller than it was on Friday.

Neither has a phone in their hand, which is itself new.

VIKRAM Repu manam kaluddam andi. Vaallu andaru vasthaaru. Rendu chairs untayi.

[Tomorrow we'll meet properly. Everyone comes. There'll be two chairs.]

She listens to him talk without understanding and without needing to.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Aa taruvatha vaallu "rendu nimishalu matladukondi" antaru. [Then they'll say, talk for two minutes.]

He laughs.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Rendu nimishalu.

He turns to her.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Manaki rendu rojulu vachayi. [We got two days.]

She doesn't know what he said.

She knows the shape of it.

SHILPAA Bikram.

VIKRAM Avunu?

SHILPAA Slowly. Say it slowly.

He is about to.

Her phone rings.

The screen lights the balcony.

BABA.

She answers.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Baba.

We stay on Vikram's face for most of the next four minutes. Her father talks. She answers. It is rapid, fluent, fully subtitled, and Vikram cannot follow a syllable — and the whole point of the scene is a man learning everything from tone.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Ha... ha, chhele bhalo... na Baba, ami age dekhini oke... Baba... [Yes... yes, the boy is nice... no Dad, I hadn't met him before... Dad...]

A pause. Her face changes.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Baba, ota bolar dorkar chhilo na. [Dad, you didn't need to say that.]

Vikram looks over.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Ma-r bari-r lok bole ami Bangali. Tomar bari-r lok bole ami South-er. Tumi ki bolo, Baba? [Mum's family says I'm the Bengali one. Your family says I'm the South one. What do you say, Dad?]

Silence on the line.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Achha. Kal dekha hobe.

She hangs up.

VIKRAM Everything okay?

She thinks about how to answer that in a language she has forty words of.

She picks the one that covers it.

SHILPAA Complicated.

CUT

EPISODE 30 END

ACT THREE — THROUGH

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 31

COLD OPEN — LOOP C.

Vikram and Shilpaa, standing three feet apart in the hall, screaming at each other.

He is shouting in Telugu. She is shouting in Bengali. Neither is pausing for the other.

VIKRAM — ADI THAPPU! ADI ASALU THAPPU!

SHILPAA — TUMI SHUNCHHO NA! TUMI EKBAR-O SHUNCHHO NA!

He points at something off-frame, violently.

She points at the same thing, more violently.

They are both furious. Nothing is legible. It looks like the end of everything.

TITLE CARD: EARLIER

INT. KITCHEN – SUNDAY MORNING – CONTINUOUS

8 AM.

Something has happened overnight that neither of them registers.

They have stopped translating.

She talks in Bengali. He replies in Telugu. It works.

SHILPAA Chal ta dhuye rekhechho? [Did you wash the rice?]

VIKRAM Rendu saarlu. [Twice.]

SHILPAA Dui bar? Beshi. [Twice? That's too much.]

VIKRAM Ma amma moodu antundi. [My mother says three.]

SHILPAA Tomar ma bhul. [Your mother is wrong.]

VIKRAM Adi nen aameku cheppanu. [I'm not telling her that.]

SHILPAA Bhitu. [Coward.]

VIKRAM Avunu.

They keep going — a complete, fluent, functional conversation in two languages, neither of which the other speaks.

Neither notices.

The audience does, because the audience has subtitles.

She hands him a plate.

SHILPAA Ei je. [Here.]

VIKRAM Dhonnobad.

Both phones are on the counter.

Both face down.

CUT

EPISODE 31 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 32

THE MUTTER, RETURNED WRONG.

She is at the dining table, working. Something in her inbox is going badly.

SHILPAA (MUTTER, not looking up) Ei lok ta ke ami mere felbo. Tin bar bolechhi. Tin bar. [I am going to murder this man. I've told him three times. Three.]

Vikram, from the sofa, catches the sounds.

He opens the diary. Flips to a page.

He has "MERE FELBO" written down from Friday night, and next to it, in his handwriting, a guess:

"MERE FELBO — happy? excited?"

He decided this because she said it, on Friday, while opening a parcel.

He smiles, pleased to have a chance to use it.

VIKRAM Shilpaa!

She looks up.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) (cheerfully, proudly, gesturing at her laptop) Mere felbo!

Shilpaa goes completely white.

SHILPAA What?

VIKRAM Mere felbo!

He gives her a thumbs up.

SHILPAA (standing up) Bikram. Where did you learn this.

VIKRAM Meere cheppinaru!

SHILPAA Where did I say it?!

VIKRAM Friday! Parcel!

Shilpaa remembers Friday. Remembers the parcel. Remembers exactly what she said about the delivery company.

She puts both hands flat on the table.

SHILPAA It means "I will kill him."

Vikram's face.

VIKRAM Ohh.

CUT

EPISODE 32 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 33

GAME 4 — 3 AM LIST

The lights are low because she turned two of them off an hour ago and neither commented.

"Five people you would text at 3 AM. In order. Then tell me why number five is not number one."

VIKRAM Idi chedda game andi.

SHILPAA Yes.

He goes first.

VIKRAM Okati — ma chelli. Rendu — Vivek, naa friend. Moodu — ma amma. Naalugu — Srikanth, office. Aidu —

He stops.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Aidu — ma nanna.

SHILPAA Why five?

VIKRAM Endukante aayana ki naa gurinchi anni telusu ani anukuntadu. Nen okka saari kuda "meeku teliyadu" ani cheppaledu. [Because he thinks he knows everything about me. I've never once told him he doesn't.]

He types it. She reads it. Twice.

SHILPAA Your father arranged this marriage.

VIKRAM Avunu.

SHILPAA And he is number five.

He has no answer.

VIKRAM Mee turn.

She counts on her fingers.

SHILPAA Ek — Ruma, amar bondhu. Dui — Arko. Tin — Baba. [One — Ruma, my friend. Two — Arko. Three — Dad.]

She stops. She looks at her fingers.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Char. [Four.]

VIKRAM Naalugu ah? Aidu?

She shakes her head.

SHILPAA Char.

CUT

EPISODE 33 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 34

He is trying to be kind and he reaches for the one Bengali word he trusts.

VIKRAM Andi. Thakbe.

Shilpaa's head comes up.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Thakbe. Meeru cheppinaru kada. Balcony lo.

She realises what he thinks it means.

She opens her mouth to correct him.

And then she doesn't.

SHILPAA Ha.

VIKRAM Correct ah?

SHILPAA Thik. [Right.]

She is not looking at him.

VIKRAM Naa pronunciation ela undi?

SHILPAA Bhalo.

He is very pleased.

He writes something in the diary with a small flourish.

She watches him do it.

She could stop this at any second.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (MUTTER, turning away) Ekdin bujhbe. Ar sedin ami kothay thakbo, ke jane. [One day he'll understand. And where I'll be that day, who knows.]

CUT

EPISODE 34 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 35

It starts as small talk and becomes a crisis in ninety seconds.

VIKRAM Andi. Manam ela relatives?

He types it, because this one has to be exact.

SHILPAA Dida-r dik theke. My mother's mother.

VIKRAM Aame peru?

She tells him.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Ooru?

She tells him.

Vikram goes very still.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Andi. Naa nanamma kuda aa oore. [My grandmother is from the same place.]

SHILPAA What?

He starts counting on his fingers.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Bikram. What.

VIKRAM Undandi. Undandi.

He counts again.

CUT

EPISODE 35 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 36

Two hours. A phone each. A pen. The back of a large calendar taped to the wall.

They build a family tree.

It is the funniest sustained sequence in the series and there is not one joke in it.

VIKRAM (on the phone) Nanna, nanamma ki entha mandi akkalu? ... Aidu ah? ... Nanna, peru lu cheppandi. [Dad, how many sisters did Grandmother have? ... Five? ... Dad, the names.]

Shilpaa is on her own phone to Kolkata, arguing with an aunt.

SHILPAA Pishi, na, Dida-r didi na, Dida-r mashi. Mashi! [Aunty, no, not Grandma's sister, Grandma's aunt. Aunt!]

They write. They cross out. They draw arrows.

At one point they both reach for the pen and conduct an entire silent negotiation about whose turn it is.

VIKRAM Aame aayanani cheskundi — ledu, aayana veru —

SHILPAA Ei to! Ei to! [Here! Here it is!]

She draws a line.

It connects.

They both step back and look at the wall.

There is a line from her grandmother to his grandmother.

It is four generations long and it is unbroken.

Silence.

VIKRAM Andi.

SHILPAA Ha.

VIKRAM Idi manchidi kaadu.

CUT

EPISODE 36 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 37

GAME 5 — THE MUTTER GAME

They are both still rattled from the wall. She is muttering continuously under her breath while she makes tea.

SHILPAA (MUTTER) Char projonmo. Char. Ar Baba kichhu bolen ni. Baba ki jano? Nishchoi jano — [Four generations. Four. And Dad said nothing. Does Dad know? He must know—]

VIKRAM Andi.

SHILPAA Hmm?

VIKRAM Meeru ippudu emi anukuntunnaro naaku cheppandi. [Tell me what you're thinking right now.]

He types it.

She reads it.

SHILPAA Why?

VIKRAM Endukante meeru roju matladutunnaru. Naaku vinipistundi. Naaku artham kaadu. [Because you talk all day. I can hear it. I don't understand it.]

She stares at him.

SHILPAA You can hear it?

VIKRAM Prathi okkati.

She puts the cup down.

SHILPAA Okay. New game. Three thoughts. Out loud. In English.

VIKRAM Modalu pettandi.

She takes a breath.

SHILPAA One. I am... I am thinking about the wall.

VIKRAM Rendu?

SHILPAA Two. I am thinking... my father did not tell me something.

VIKRAM Moodu?

She opens her mouth.

And nothing comes.

She tries again.

SHILPAA Three. I am —

She stops.

Eleven seconds.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) I cannot.

VIKRAM Enduku?

SHILPAA (and this one is in English, and it costs her) Because in English I am a smaller person.

CUT

EPISODE 37 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 38

LOOP C CLOSES.

TITLE CARD: NOW

The same frame as Episode 31. Three feet apart. Both shouting.

And now we see what is off-frame.

It is the wall. The calendar. The family tree.

And they are arguing about a woman called Kalyani who died in 1961 and whether she was a sister or a cousin.

VIKRAM — ADI THAPPU! ADI ASALU THAPPU! Aame aayana chelli kaadu andi! Aame aayana mena kodalu! [— That's wrong! That's completely wrong! She wasn't his sister! She was his cousin's daughter-in-law!]

SHILPAA — TUMI SHUNCHHO NA! EKBAR-O SHUNCHHO NA! Pishi bolechhe Kalyani Dida-r didi! [— You're not listening! Not once! Auntie said Kalyani was Grandma's older sister!]

VIKRAM Mee pishi ki gurthu ledu!

SHILPAA Tomar baba-r-o nei!

He grabs the pen and adds a line.

She grabs it back and crosses it out.

He takes it and draws a different line.

She crosses that out too.

They are now both drawing on the same square inch of calendar, at speed, shouting.

And then Vikram stops, pen in hand, and says, in a completely different voice:

VIKRAM Andi.

SHILPAA Ki?!

VIKRAM Manam ippudu rendu bhashallo oka chanipoyina ammayi gurinchi kottukuntunnam.
[We are currently fighting in two languages about a woman who is dead.]

Shilpaa stops.

She looks at the wall.

She looks at the pen in her hand.

And she starts laughing.

CUT

EPISODE 38 END

INT. FLAT – DAY – EPISODE 39

The calls come back.

VIKRAM Naa nanna cheppadu. Aa sambandam — adi pelli valla. Rakta sambandam kaadu.
[My father says — that connection is by marriage. Not blood.]

He types all of it, carefully.

She reads it.

SHILPAA Amar pishi-o tai bollo. [My aunt said the same.]

She types it.

He reads it.

They both look at the wall.

VIKRAM Ante manam —

SHILPAA Amra kichhu na. [We're nothing.]

VIKRAM Emi kaadu.

SHILPAA Kichhu na.

And then the relief arrives, and it is enormous, and it is completely out of proportion, and both of them feel it at the same time and both of them see the other feel it.

Which is much worse than the panic was.

They stand in front of a wall covered in dead relatives, three feet apart, having just discovered that there is no obstacle.

Neither of them says anything.

Shilpaa takes the calendar off the wall and folds it.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Cha? [Tea?]

VIKRAM Ha.

Neither moves toward the kitchen.

CUT

EPISODE 39 END

INT. FLAT – AFTERNOON – EPISODE 40

Sunday afternoon. Hour forty-eight.

The flat is completely theirs now. Two mugs on the rack. His diary on the dining table. Her book face down on the sofa arm. His charger in her socket.

She folds laundry. He carries the basket without being asked.

SHILPAA Oi ta amar. [That one's mine.]

VIKRAM Telusu.

She looks up.

SHILPAA How do you know?

VIKRAM Rendu rojulu ayindi andi.

She folds the towel.

SHILPAA Dui din.

VIKRAM Dui din.

She looks at him when he says it in Bengali. He doesn't notice.

TIME CUT.

Late afternoon. Both reading. Different sofas. Complete silence. Entirely comfortable.

She looks up at one point.

He is asleep, sitting up, book on his chest.

SHILPAA (MUTTER, very quietly) Ei je. Erokom-i to chai chhilam. Ei tuku. [This. This is all I ever wanted. Just this much.]

She goes back to her book.

CUT

EPISODE 40 END

INT. FLAT – EVENING – EPISODE 41

His phone buzzes. Email.

He opens it. Reads.

He reads it again.

He sits up.

SHILPAA Ki? [What?]

VIKRAM Emi ledu.

SHILPAA Bikram.

VIKRAM Office.

SHILPAA Achha.

She goes back to her book.

He reads it a third time.

Over his shoulder:

"Offer — Senior Design Lead — Bangalore — 18 months"

He looks at her across the room.

She is reading with her feet under her, entirely unaware.

He locks the phone. Puts it face down.

VIKRAM Shilpaa.

She looks up.

SHILPAA Hmm?

VIKRAM Emi ledu.

CUT

EPISODE 41 END

INT. FLAT – AFTERNOON – EPISODE 42

GAME 6 — THE MUTE HOUR

She writes the rule on paper and holds it up.

"1 HOUR. NO TALKING. ANY LANGUAGE. GO."

He nods.

She starts a timer.

Forty seconds of screen time covering fifty-two minutes of clock time. All gesture.

00:04 — He asks for water. She points at the fridge. He mimes gratitude enormously.

00:11 — She reads. He watches her read. She looks up. He looks away too late.

00:19 — He mimes a question about the book. She mimes the plot. It involves a boat and, apparently, a murder.

00:26 — They eat. He gestures that the food is good. She gestures that she knows.

00:33 — She opens her mouth to mutter, catches herself, and closes it. Her hand goes to her mouth. **This is the biggest thing that happens in the episode.**

00:35 — He sees her do it.

00:44 — He gets up. Crosses the room. Sits on the floor near her chair. Not touching.

00:52 — Neither has moved in eight minutes.

Then he breaks it.

Quietly, in Telugu, not as a joke:

VIKRAM Naaku ee repu ravaddu ani undi. [I don't want tomorrow to come.]

The timer is still running.

She looks at him.

CUT

EPISODE 42 END

INT. FLAT – AFTERNOON – EPISODE 43

She doesn't ask what it meant.

She doesn't reach for the phone.

They stay there.

Then she says:

SHILPAA Jani na. Kintu ami bujhechhi. [I don't know. But I understood.]

He doesn't ask either.

The timer beeps. Neither turns it off for a while.

She does, eventually.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) One hour.

VIKRAM Nen tappa chesa. [I broke it.]

SHILPAA Ha.

VIKRAM Sorry.

SHILPAA Na.

She gets up. Goes to the kitchen.

He stays on the floor by the empty chair.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (MUTTER, from the kitchen, filling a pan) Ek ghonta chup thakte parlam. Ekhono kotha bolar dorkar hoy ni. Ei prothom. Ar ora bole ami beshi kotha boli. [I managed an hour in silence. I didn't need to talk. First time ever. And they say I talk too much.]

CUT

EPISODE 43 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 44

He goes to get the diary off the dining table and it isn't there.

It is on the arm of her sofa, open, with her pen beside it.

She comes out of the kitchen.

VIKRAM Meeru naa book —

SHILPAA Ha. Mistakes. Many.

She picks it up and hands it back.

He turns to the back pages. Seventy-four words now. Every correction in her handwriting.

And then he turns one more page.

There is a page that is not his.

Bengali script. Two columns. About sixty lines.

VIKRAM Idi enti?

SHILPAA Amar. [Mine.]

He can't read a word of it. He turns it toward the light anyway.

VIKRAM Idi Bengali.

SHILPAA Ha. Bangla akshor.

She takes the pen. Points at a line. Reads it aloud.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) "Ekkada."

VIKRAM Ekkada?!

SHILPAA Ha. Ekkada — kothay.

She points at the next line.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) "Cheppandi."

VIKRAM Idi Telugu andi! Bengali akshram lo!

SHILPAA Ha.

VIKRAM Eppatnunchi?

SHILPAA Shukrobar raat theke. [Since Friday night.]

He counts backwards.

Friday night was the bathroom door.

VIKRAM Andi, Friday raatri meeru naa meeda kopam ga unnaru. [Friday night you were furious with me.]

SHILPAA Ha.

VIKRAM Aithe?

SHILPAA (a beat, and then, simply) Adi. Sedin-i shuru korechhi. [That's when I started.]

She takes the diary back to correct one more line.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Adi, ei ta bhul. [Adi, this one's wrong.]

He stops.

VIKRAM Enti annaru?

SHILPAA Ki?

VIKRAM Meeru ippude —

SHILPAA (not looking up) Adi.

CUT

EPISODE 44 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 45

Later. Both on the floor.

SHILPAA Adi.

VIKRAM Hmm.

SHILPAA Shukrobar. Bathroom-er baire. Tumi onek kotha bolechhile. [Friday. Outside the bathroom. You said a lot of things.]

He half-understands. "Shukrobar" is in the diary. "Bathroom" is a loan word.

VIKRAM Friday ah?

SHILPAA Ha.

VIKRAM Meeku emi artham kaledu kada.

She looks at him.

And then she says it. In Telugu. Slowly. Accent completely wrong, every word in the right place.

SHILPAA "Nen deenni repair chestha andi. Nen manchi gum techhi." [I'll repair this. I'll get good glue.]

Vikram does not move.

VIKRAM Meeru —

SHILPAA Ami likhe rekhechhilam. Shune shune. Tarpore phone-e khuje ber korlam. [I wrote it down. From listening. Then I looked it up on the phone.]

VIKRAM Meeku aa raatri artham aindaa?

SHILPAA Na. Oi raate na. [No. Not that night.]

VIKRAM Eppudu?

SHILPAA Shonibar. [Saturday.]

Vikram sits with the fact that she has known for twenty-four hours.

VIKRAM Aa bowl gurinchi nen ippatiki kuda — [About that bowl, I still—]

SHILPAA Adi.

VIKRAM Avunu.

SHILPAA Ota char number chhilo na. [It wasn't number four.]

He looks at her.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Ekta-i chhilo. [There was only one.]

CUT

EPISODE 45 END

ACT FOUR — CHOSEN

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 46

COLD OPEN — LOOP D.

Shilpaa, alone, sitting on the floor of her bedroom with her back against the bed.

She is holding Vikram's diary, open.

She is crying. Properly. Silently. Both hands around the book.

Eight seconds.

TITLE CARD: EARLIER

INT. FLAT – SUNDAY NIGHT – CONTINUOUS

10 PM.

He stands up. Goes to the dining table. Picks up the diary. Comes back. Sits down. Opens it.

VIKRAM Shilpaa.

SHILPAA Hmm.

He takes a breath.

And then he speaks Bengali. On purpose. Slowly. Reading half of it off a page, getting about a third of it wrong.

VIKRAM Ami... Bangla jani na.

SHILPAA Jani. [I know.]

VIKRAM Kintu... ami... shikhchi. [But... I... am learning.]

She sits up.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Tumi... ekhane... ekta ghor-e... ekla chhile.

He loses the sentence. Checks the page. Finds it.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Ami dekhechhi. Ar amio. [I saw. And me too.]

The Bengali is broken and the accent is a disaster.

Shilpaa does not move.

SHILPAA Koto khon dhore likhchile? [How long were you writing that?]

VIKRAM Enti?

She points at the diary.

SHILPAA How long?

VIKRAM (quietly) Rendu gantalu. [Two hours.]

She looks at the diary. Then at him.

CUT

EPISODE 46 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 47

SHILPAA Two hours.

VIKRAM Avunu.

SHILPAA For four sentences.

VIKRAM Naalugu andi. Avunu.

SHILPAA (MUTTER, turning away, and this one she does not manage to keep quiet) Keu amar bhasha-y ekta kotha bolar jonno duto ghonta — [Two hours, for someone to say one thing in my language—]

She stops.

She turns back.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Sorry.

VIKRAM Enduku sorry?

SHILPAA I talk. To myself. All the time. It is a — habit.

VIKRAM Naaku telusu.

SHILPAA It is not normal.

VIKRAM Andi.

He picks the diary up and holds it out.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Idi antha meere. [All of this is you.]

She looks at the book.

CUT

EPISODE 47 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 48

GAME 7 — CLOSE FRIENDS

SHILPAA Close friends list. Open. Last person added. Last person removed.

VIKRAM Idi chedda game andi.

SHILPAA All of them are.

He goes first.

VIKRAM Added — Vivek. Rendu nelala kindata. Removed — Priya. Padhi nelalu.

SHILPAA Who?

VIKRAM Adi pedda story andi.

SHILPAA Short.

VIKRAM Aame naa meeda edho anukundi. Nen edho anukunna. Rendu okkati kaadu. [She thought one thing about me. I thought another. They weren't the same thing.]

He types it. She reads it. Nods. Doesn't dig.

Her turn.

She opens the list.

SHILPAA Added — Ruma. Three years.

VIKRAM Removed?

She doesn't scroll. She doesn't need to.

SHILPAA January.

He waits.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Ma-r account.

She looks at the screen.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Ekdin dekhte parchhila na. Tai bad diye dilam. Tarpore ek ghonta pore abar add korlam. Tarpore abar bad dilam. [One day I couldn't bear to see it. So I removed it. Then an hour later I added it back. Then I removed it again.]

She puts the phone face down.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Ekhono add kora achhe. [It's still added.]

CUT

EPISODE 48 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 49

He does not say anything.

He does not reach for the phone or the translator.

He moves from his chair to the floor beside her sofa, the way he did during the mute hour, and sits down, and stays.

Two minutes of screen time. Play all of it.

She doesn't cry.

She talks a little, in Bengali, not to him — just out loud, to the room, in the way people do when somebody is present and not participating.

SHILPAA (MUTTER) Uni amake Bangla shikhiyechhilen. Ma. Kintu nijer bhasha ta bhule giyechhilen. Ami kokhono jiggesh korini oke kemon legechhilo. [She taught me Bengali. Mum. But she'd forgotten her own language. I never once asked her how that felt.]

He listens to a language he does not have.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (MUTTER) Ekbar-o na.

After a while she stops.

After a longer while she puts her hand on the top of his head, briefly, and takes it away.

VIKRAM Shilpaa.

SHILPAA Hmm.

VIKRAM Nen ikkade unna. [I'm right here.]

SHILPAA Jani. [I know.]

CUT

EPISODE 49 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 50

Later. 1 AM.

He picks up the diary.

VIKRAM Andi. Nen okati chestha.

SHILPAA Ki?

He turns to the back and starts reading her own mutters back to her.

All ninety-one. In order. In his terrible phonetic approximation.

VIKRAM Ki holo. Bajey. Ei re. Amar. Bhogoban. Na na na. Baba. Ma. Thok bee. Bhitu. Uff. Mere felbo...

She listens.

He is reading her three days back at her from the outside.

Her own interior monologue, transcribed by a man who could not understand one word of it while she was saying it.

He gets to word sixty.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Ei tuku.

Shilpaa's face.

She remembers saying that one. Sunday afternoon. Looking at him asleep on the sofa.

She had thought nobody heard it.

She says nothing.

He keeps reading.

CUT

EPISODE 50 END

INT. SHILPAA'S ROOM – NIGHT – EPISODE 51

LOOP D CLOSES.

TITLE CARD: NOW

The same frame as Episode 46.

Shilpaa on the floor of her bedroom, back against the bed, the diary open in both hands.

She is crying.

And now we see what page it is open at.

Word thirty-one.

"THOK BEE — thank you (?)"

And underneath it, in his handwriting, added tonight, in a different pen:

"Shilpaa balcony. Plant. Friday. She was asking it to stay."

He worked it out.

He worked it out and he did not tell her.

She turns the page.

There is one more line, at the bottom, in his handwriting:

"Nen kuda." "me too"

She closes the diary.

She holds it against her chest with both arms.

Eight seconds.

Then she gets up, wipes her face, and goes out into the hall as though nothing has happened, because that is what she has always done.

CUT

EPISODE 51 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 52

GAME 8 — DUI HAAT

She explains it entirely in gesture, which by now is a language they are both fluent in.

Right palm up. Flat. Facing him.

His palm, opposite. An inch of air.

She moves, he mirrors.

First one to touch, loses.

VIKRAM Time limit?

SHILPAA Na.

They sit cross-legged on the floor, facing each other.

She raises her palm. He raises his.

An inch of air.

She moves left. He follows. Up. He follows. Slow circle. He follows.

She speeds up. He keeps up.

She stops dead. He stops.

The inch holds.

Neither is looking at the hands.

TIME CUT — **00:08:00**. Slower now. The distance is less than an inch.

TIME CUT — **00:15:00**. Barely moving. Two palms, almost touching, two people who have not blinked in a while.

TIME CUT — **00:22:00**. Completely still.

Both hands trembling very slightly, from being held up for twenty-two minutes and from the other reason.

SHILPAA Adi.

VIKRAM Hmm.

SHILPAA Ami harbo na. [I won't lose.]

VIKRAM Nen kuda.

Neither moves.

CUT TO BLACK.

EPISODE 52 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 53

Midnight.

Her phone buzzes on the counter. Then his.

She looks.

SHILPAA Flight. Kal shokal-e. [Tomorrow morning.]

VIKRAM Enni ganta laki?

SHILPAA Shaat-ta. Airport. Tarpur —

She checks the second message.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Egaro-ta. Ekhane.

VIKRAM Padakonda ah?

SHILPAA Ha. Egaro-ta. Pellichupulu.

She says the Telugu word and it lands strangely in her mouth and both of them hear it.

VIKRAM Padakonda gantalaki.

He looks at the clock. 12:04 AM.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Padakonda gantalu. [Eleven hours.]

They both work it out at the same moment and neither says it out loud.

SHILPAA Adi. Tomorrow. Two chairs. Your parents. My father. My aunty. Thirty minutes. Tea. Then they ask us. Then they decide.

VIKRAM Avunu.

SHILPAA They will ask me one question in Telugu and I will not understand it.

VIKRAM Nen translate chestha.

SHILPAA Then they will know.

He stops.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) They think I manage. My father told them "she manages."

VIKRAM Meeru manage cheyyaru andi. Meeru bathikestunnaru. [You don't manage. You survive.]

He doesn't type that one.

CUT

EPISODE 53 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 54

1:10 AM.

She has been quiet for twenty minutes.

Then she says it in English, which she hates, which is why it costs her something.

SHILPAA Adi. One question.

VIKRAM Cheppandi.

SHILPAA If no families. No photo. No Kolkata. No father, no aunty, no — this.

She makes a small gesture at the whole apparatus.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) You see me. On a road. Any road.

A beat.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) You choose?

CUT

EPISODE 54 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 55

He answers in Telugu. At length. Because it is the only place he has enough words.

VIKRAM Nen ee prashna ki Telugu lo cheptha andi. Endukante naaku English lo antha

raadhu. [I'll answer this in Telugu. Because I don't have enough English for it.]

She doesn't stop him.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Nen Friday naalugu pathi ki ee talupu daggara nilabaddanu. Naaku mee gurinchi okkate vishayam telusu. Mee peru. Anthe. [I stood at that door at ten past four on Friday. I knew one thing about you. Your name. That's all.]

She listens.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Meeru talupu teesaru. Mee mokham meeda pacchha undi. Talaki cap undi. Meeru naa vaipu chusi "you are early" annaru. [You opened the door. There was green on your face. A cap on your head. You looked at me and said "you are early."]

He half-laughs.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Naaku aa kshanam lo emi anipinchindo cheppana? [Shall I tell you what I felt in that moment?]

He looks at her.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Nen bhayapadaledu. Nen sanoshapadaledu. Naaku okkate anipinchindi — "ee ammayi asalu ela untundo naaku ippude telisipoindi." [I wasn't nervous. I wasn't pleased. I felt one thing — "I have just found out exactly what this girl is actually like."]

He stops.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Rendu rojula tarvatha nen ippudu nerchukunna. Aa nalabhai nimishalu — adi ne asalu meeru. Migathadi antha meeru rendella nunchi chestunna acting. [Two days later I've learnt something. Those forty minutes — that was actually you. Everything after it was a performance you've been doing for years.]

She has understood almost none of the words.

SHILPAA Ki bolle? [What did you say?]

VIKRAM Nen tarvatha cheptha. [I'll tell you later.]

CUT

EPISODE 55 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 56

GAME 9 — BOLO NA

3 AM.

She explains it with her hands and one English word.

She points at her own mouth. Then at his ear. Then makes a small "quiet" sign.

SHILPAA Whisper.

Then she points at her own heart, and makes a question mark in the air.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Guess. Not word. Feeling.

VIKRAM Artham kaledu andi.

She holds up a finger. Waits.

Then she moves.

She comes and sits beside him — not opposite — and leans in, and puts her mouth close to his ear.

Close enough that he goes completely still.

And she whispers a full sentence in Bengali, low and slow, directly into his ear.

No subtitle. The first of only two in sixty episodes.

She sits back.

SHILPAA Ki? [What?]

Vikram does not answer for a while.

He is not thinking about the words. He is not able to think about the words.

VIKRAM Meeru —

He stops. Starts again.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Meeru bhayapadutunnaru. [You're frightened.]

She looks at him.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Kani sorry cheppatledu. [But you're not apologising for it.]

Shilpaa does not say whether he is right.

She doesn't have to. Her face does it.

SHILPAA Tomar pala. [Your turn.]

She turns her head. Offers her ear. Waits.

He hesitates.

Then he leans in and whispers, in Telugu, for about seven seconds.

No subtitle. The second and last.

He sits back.

She does not guess.

She does not say anything at all.

VIKRAM Meeru guess cheyyali andi.

She shakes her head. Slowly.

SHILPAA Na.

She stays exactly where she is.

Which is very close.

CUT

EPISODE 56 END

INT. FLAT – NIGHT – EPISODE 57

4:20 AM.

They are sitting side by side against the sofa, shoulders touching, which is the most contact there has been in fifty-seven episodes.

SHILPAA Adi.

VIKRAM Hmm.

SHILPAA Ghum pachhe. [I'm sleepy.]

VIKRAM Nen kuda.

Neither moves.

TIME CUT — 4:41 AM.

She has fallen asleep. Sitting up. Her head has gone onto his shoulder at the angle that means she did not decide to.

Vikram does not move.

He looks straight ahead.

TIME CUT — 5:30 AM.

He still hasn't moved. His arm has gone dead. He adjusts it a millimetre and she shifts and he freezes completely until she settles.

TIME CUT — 5:52 AM. First grey light.

He is still awake.

He is smiling at nothing, in a dark hall, at six in the morning, with a dead arm.

VIKRAM (very quietly, to nobody) Nen ippudu okkasari alochinchanu. [I have thought about it now.]

CUT

EPISODE 57 END

INT. FLAT – MORNING – EPISODE 58

7:00 AM.

She wakes on the sofa with a cushion under her head she did not put there and a blanket she did not fetch.

He is in the kitchen. Fully dressed. Ironed shirt.

Neither acknowledges anything.

VIKRAM Good morning.

SHILPAA Good morning.

VIKRAM Tea?

SHILPAA Ha.

He makes it. No sugar, less milk. He does not ask.

She notices that he did not ask. She says nothing.

Then she turns around and looks at the flat.

The calendar with the family tree, folded on the table. Two mugs. His diary. Her notebook. A blanket on the sofa. Three pieces of a ceramic bowl, still arranged in the shape of a bowl.

Three days of evidence, in every direction.

SHILPAA Adi.

VIKRAM Hmm.

She gestures at the room.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Ohh.

THE CLEAN-UP. Forty seconds, executed like a heist.

The calendar into a drawer. The blanket folded to a sharpness it has never known. His trolley bag dragged out and positioned by the front door, packed, as though he arrived twenty minutes ago.

The three pieces of the bowl go into a kitchen cupboard.

He reaches for the diary.

She gets there first.

She picks it up.

He holds out his hand.

She doesn't give it to him.

She walks to her own room. Opens her own drawer. Puts the diary inside. Closes it.

She comes back out.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Andi, adi naa—

SHILPAA Ha.

VIKRAM Meeru —

SHILPAA Ha.

He decides not to argue.

VIKRAM Sare.

CUT

EPISODE 58 END

INT. FLAT – MONDAY 10:50 AM – EPISODE 59

MASTER LOOP CLOSSES.

TITLE CARD: MONDAY, 11:00 AM

Both phones go at once.

He answers his. She answers hers. Six feet apart, two conversations, two languages.

VIKRAM Amma! ... Avunu, nen hotel lo unna ... Ledu amma, nen mundu ne vellipotha ...
Padakonda ki. Avunu.

SHILPAA Baba. Ha. Baba, tomra kokhon—

A pause.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Ekhon? [Now?]

She turns.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Baba, tumi kothay?

She listens.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Achha.

She hangs up.

Vikram hangs up.

VIKRAM Enti?

SHILPAA Baba. "Ami eshe pouchhechhi." [Dad. "I've arrived."]

They look at each other.

They look at the flat. Two chairs pulled out. Tea things laid.

She goes to the door.

And we are now in the Episode 1 frame. Same lens. Same blocking. Same light.

She puts her hand on the latch.

She does not open it.

The doorbell rings.

Neither moves.

From outside, muffled — two voices. One Bengali. One Telugu. Both at once. Neither understanding the other. Extremely cheerful.

Shilpaa turns her head and looks back at him.

He looks at her.

Twelve seconds.

The doorbell rings again.

AND NOW WE GO PAST IT.

Shilpaa takes her hand off the latch.

She turns all the way around.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Adi.

VIKRAM Hmm.

She starts laughing — silently, helplessly, one hand over her mouth — while four relatives conduct an entirely failed conversation on the other side of the wood.

He starts too.

She wipes her eyes.

She turns back to the door. Hand on the latch.

And he says it.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Shilpaa.

She stops.

VIKRAM (CONT'D) Thakbe?

Shilpaa goes completely still.

Because she knows what he used to think it meant.

And she knows he found out.

She turns around.

CUT

EPISODE 59 END

INT. FLAT – MONDAY 11:00 AM – EPISODE 60

She looks at him.

The doorbell rings a third time.

SHILPAA Adi.

VIKRAM Avunu.

SHILPAA Tumi jano ota mane ki? [Do you know what that means?]

VIKRAM Telusu.

SHILPAA Kobe theke? [Since when?]

VIKRAM Ninna raatri. [Last night.]

She nods slowly.

SHILPAA Ar tumi kichhu bolo ni. [And you said nothing.]

VIKRAM Ledu.

SHILPAA Keno? [Why?]

He thinks about how to say it.

Then he says it in Bengali, badly, and it is the last of his ninety-one words and he has been saving it.

VIKRAM Karon... ami... tomake jiggesh korte chai. Ekhon. [Because... I... want to ask you. Now.]

Shilpaa closes her eyes.

SHILPAA Thakbo. [I'll stay.]

She opens them.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) Ha. Thakbo.

He lets out a breath he has been holding since Friday at ten past four.

The doorbell rings again, longer, and now somebody is knocking as well.

She reaches out and straightens his collar. Once.

He reaches out and takes the pen out of her hair, which she forgot about at seven this morning.

They both look at the pen.

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (MUTTER, and the last one of the season) Bhogoban. Tin din. Tin din-e ei manush ta amar shob kotha shune felechhe. [God. Three days. In three days this man has heard every single thing I've said.]

VIKRAM Enti annaru?

SHILPAA Later.

She opens the door.

Light. Noise. Two families talking over each other in two languages, and the sound of a great many people coming in at once.

We do not see them.

We hold on the two of them, in the hall, side by side, facing the door.

CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD: FOURTEEN MONTHS LATER

INT. THE SAME FLAT – MORNING

The same hall.

Redressed. Married. Two of everything now — two chairs at the table, two laptops, a second bookshelf that does not match the first.

On the wall, framed, are three pieces of a ceramic bowl, joined with visible gold.

7:00 AM. An ordinary Tuesday.

Shilpaa is at the table, on a laptop, working.

Vikram comes out of the bedroom with a suitcase. A proper one. Packed.

He puts it by the door.

She doesn't look up.

VIKRAM Nen bayaluderthunna. [I'm leaving.]

SHILPAA Hmm.

VIKRAM Shilpaa.

SHILPAA Hmm.

He stands there.

She keeps typing.

He picks up the suitcase.

And as he opens the door, she says — quietly, to herself, turned away, in Bengali, exactly the

way she has said everything for fourteen months:

SHILPAA (CONT'D) (MUTTER) Jiggesh korbe na. Ekbar-o jiggesh korbe na. [He won't ask. He won't ask even once.]

Vikram stops in the doorway.

He has understood every word.

CUT TO BLACK.

Screen reads: Season 1 Samaptham. / Prothom Porbo Shesh.

EPISODE 60 END

10. DIRECTION NOTES

1. **Never subtitle a mutter for the character.** The subtitles are for the audience alone. Every scene must play correctly with subtitles switched off.
2. **She never mutters at him.** Body turned away, hands occupied, mid-task, every single time. The moment she plays it as a stage aside, the device dies and the series with it.
3. **Two whispers go unsubtitled** — Episodes 56, both of them. They are the only lines in sixty episodes the audience does not get. Do not add them in the compilation cut. Tell the actors to say something real, and never release it.
4. **The five loop pairs are one take each, split in the edit.** Eps 1/59, 2/12, 13/22, 31/38, 46/51. Shoot each once, cut it twice. That is the only way the match is exact, and the match is the entire pleasure of the device.
5. **"Thakbe" gets no music. Ever.** Not in Ep 9, not 21, not 34, not 51, not 59. If a score cue lands on it at any point in the season, the ending is gone.
6. **Her English and her Bengali are two different performances.** In English she is clipped, efficient, sixty percent of a person. In Bengali she is fast, funny, three steps ahead. The actor plays two women. The character knows it — that is what Episode 37 is for.
7. **The face pack and the dye must be real and must hold continuity across eleven episodes shot out of order.** Photograph every stage on day one. This is the single most likely thing to go wrong in production.
8. **He never corrects "Bikram."** Not once, from Episode 29 to Episode 60. Nobody mentions it. The audience will.

9. **His Hindi is confidently wrong throughout** and nobody ever corrects that either.
 10. **Episode 49 is two minutes of a man saying nothing.** Play all of it. Do not cut to anything.
 11. **No third face. Ever.** Sixty episodes, two people. The families in Episodes 59 and 60 are voices through a door and then light through an open one. Nobody steps into frame.
 12. **The bowl is repaired in gold in the flash-forward.** Nobody points at it. No insert. It is on a wall, in the background, for eleven seconds.
-

11. RELEASE NOTE

Sixty episodes at one a day is two months of daily uploads.

Premiere block of six, then daily at a fixed time, with a double drop every Saturday. Act breaks — after 12, 30, 45 — get a one-day gap each, announced in advance.

The non-linear structure is a marketing asset. Every loop close (Eps 12, 22, 38, 51, 59) is a "go back and watch it again" moment, and each one sends viewers back to an earlier episode — which is watch time you have already paid for.

Compilation: cut as two films. *Thakbe? Part One* (Eps 1–30, ending on "Complicated") and *Part Two* (31–60). In the compilation, **keep the loops**. Do not linearise them. The non-linearity is the grammar of the piece.

12. SEASON 2 — THE PROMISE

FOURTEEN MONTHS

The door in Episode 60 doesn't close. Season 2 starts in the doorway.

He has a packed suitcase and an eighteen-month posting he accepted without asking her. She has fourteen months of things she has said out loud in a language he now understands — and she has only just found out that he understands them.

Which means she has no private room left anywhere, including inside her own head.

Season 2 is the thing three rainy days never had to answer: two people who fell in love across a language barrier, now living inside a marriage where the barrier is gone, and finding out that understanding every word your partner says to herself is not the same thing as being able to live with her.

Plus Kolkata. Her father's house. Her mother's family. And, for the first time in the whole show, **other people in the frame.**

Same flat. Same two faces. And nothing left to hide behind.